



Armed STALEMATE

The pay packet battle for lieutenant colonels leads to a serious impasse between the military and government

By Sandeep Unnithan

For over three months now nearly 22,000 lieutenant colonel-ranked officers have been taking home a pay packet that is Rs 8,000 less than their civilian counterparts as per the recommendations of the Sixth Central Pay Commission (CPC). This, even as the eight other ranks of the armed forces have continued to draw their new pay scales under the sixth CPC.

This is because lieutenant colonels and their equivalent commanders and wing commanders in the navy and air force who make up over 40 per cent of the entire officer cadre of the armed forces, are at the centre of a contentious battle between the Government and

services. It began with a letter dated January 1 from the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) elevating lieutenant colonels into a more lucrative Pay Band-4 (PB) which would entitle them to a Rs 8,000 pay increase. The services have since last year agitated for including lieutenant colonels (a rank reached after 13 years of service) in PB-4 along with their civilian counterparts. However, the PMO missive comes with a rider: it forbids them from being sent on deputations to services like the National Security Guard (NSG) and the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO).

The pay hike will cost just Rs 30 crore every year but the Government

Men in the Muddle

- Govt puts lieutenant colonels in higher PB-4 but stops their deputations to other services
- Services say that the move will reduce combat worthiness, asks for withdrawal of order
- Impasse has halted PB-4 salaries to nearly 22,000 officers

Organisations Affected

National Cadet Corps



1,000

DRDO



100